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SECTOR AT A GLANCE 07

Rural: Handwashing with Soap in India

WASH in India

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WASH IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

Hand hygiene, particularly handwashing with soap, is recognised as a highly cost-effective public health intervention that can prevent diseases such as diarrhoea and respiratory infections, helping reduce infant and child mortality and improving child survival rates.

The COVID-19 pandemic has reiterated that proper hand hygiene is indispensable in preventing and controlling infections.

However, as per data from the 78th National Sample Survey (NSS), handwashing practices remain inadequate in rural India, with 23% of rural households still without handwashing facilities with soap and water.¹ Limited access to soap, water scarcity, lack of proper handwashing stations, knowledge gaps, and ingrained habits deter hand hygiene while inadequate sanitation exacerbates risks of faecal-oral contamination.

Given these challenges, focused efforts to promote handwashing with soap through community-based programs, behaviour change communication, and provision of handwashing facilities can significantly improve hand hygiene practices and health outcomes in rural areas. Several ongoing and recent central government initiatives, including but not limited to the Swachh Bharat Mission Gramin (SBM-G), the Kayakalp initiative, and the National Rural Health Mission focus on promoting effective rural handwashing practices.

This note presents some key statistics and trends, challenges, and opportunities, as well as some ideas for the way forward to improve rates of handwashing with soap in India.

Figure 1: Key rural handwashing statistics

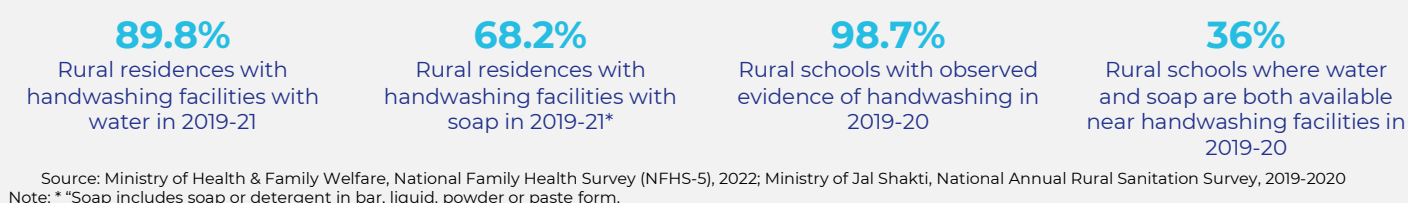
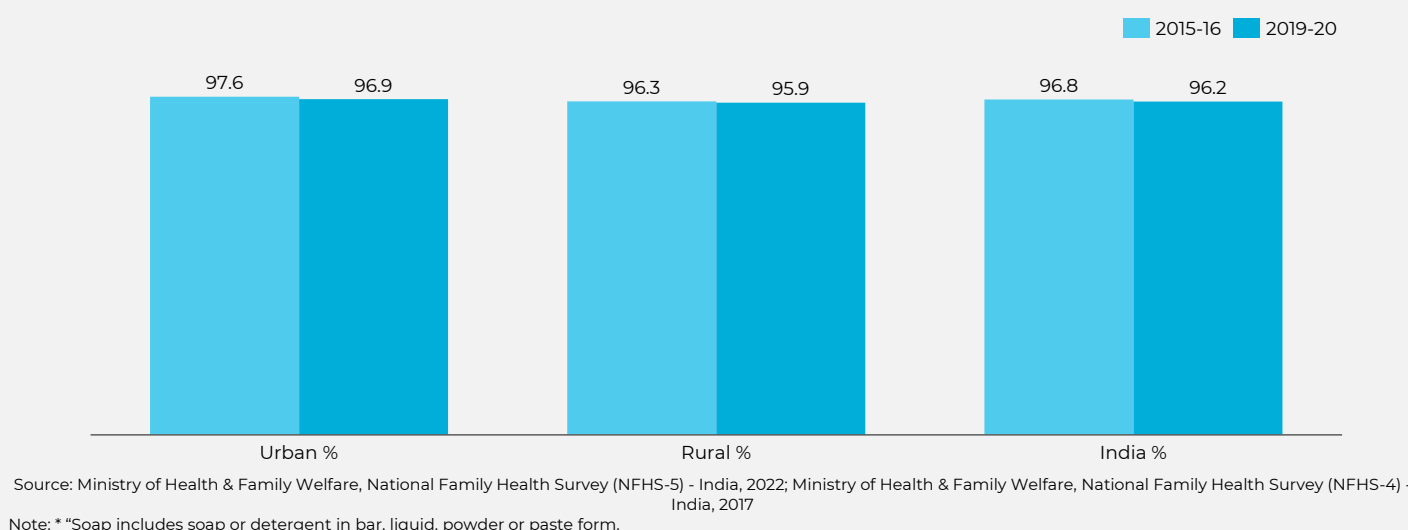
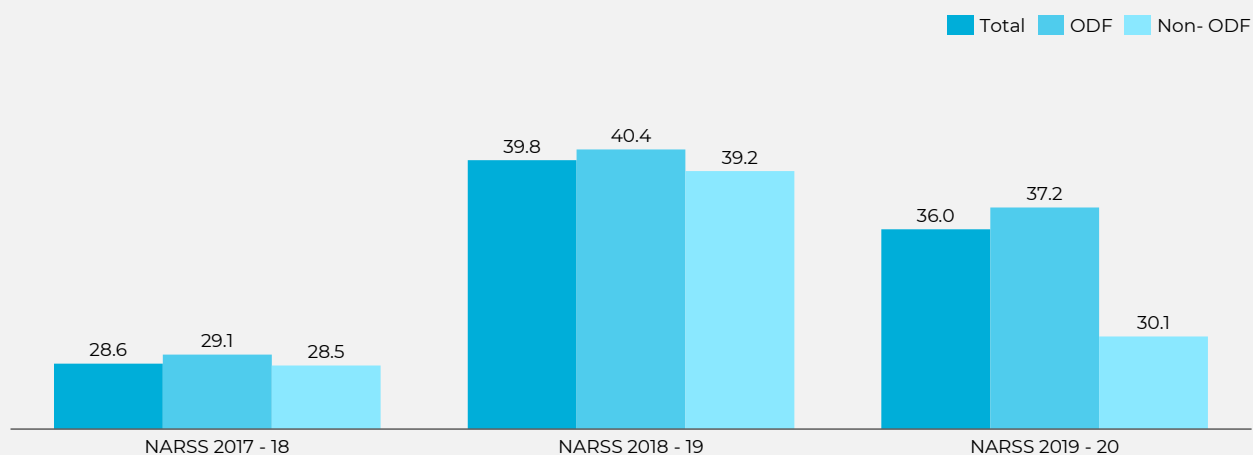


Figure 2: Percentage of urban and rural residences in which place for handwashing was observed, 2015-16 and 2019-21



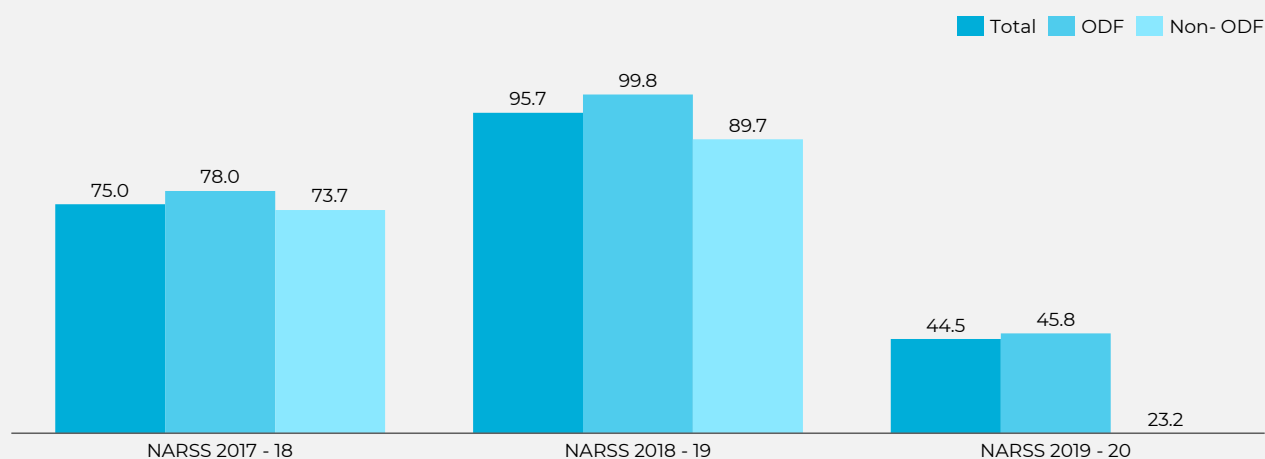
¹ MoSPI, Multiple Indicator Survey in India, 78th Round, (2020-21), 2023

Figure 3: Percentage of rural schools with evidence of handwashing practices (i.e., both water and soap available for toilet use) by ODF status (2017-18, 2018-19, and 2019-20)



Source: Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Surveys, (2017-18, 2018-19, and 2019-20)

Figure 4: Percentage of public toilets by evidence of handwashing practices (i.e., soap or water available near the toilet) by ODF status (2017-18, 2018-19, and 2019-20)



Source: Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Surveys, (2017-18, 2018-19, and 2019-20)

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective rural handwashing practices. These revolve primarily around reductions in disease burden through increased awareness of handwashing habits and improved educational outcomes.



Improved awareness among households:

Awareness and behaviour change are critical to ensure sustained handwashing habits.² Effective handwashing techniques can be promoted through Accredited Social Health Activists and Auxiliary Nurses and Midwives, using affordable soaps, portable handwashing stations, and also mass media campaigns for broader awareness. Such interventions can potentially increase the visibility of handwashing as a key behaviour and reduce the disease burden among the rural population.



Improved educational outcomes:

Handwashing was observed in ~99% of rural schools in 2019-2020.³ This positive trend can continue with sustained efforts to maintain child-friendly handwashing stations near school toilets. Regular handwashing sessions before midday meals can help instil the habit in children. Training teachers to monitor handwashing demonstrate proper techniques and incorporate hygiene education into the curriculum can spread awareness and also result in positive spillovers since children often carry these practices back home. These school-level interventions can ensure that children are healthier and perform better in school.⁴

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing rural handwashing practices in India.



Insufficient handwashing infrastructure in households and schools:

About ~23% of the rural population did not have access to hand washing facilities with water and soap/detergent within the premises in 2020-21.⁵ Additionally, only 36% of schools in rural India have water and soap available for handwashing, reports the National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey 2019-20.⁶ In most schools, only water was available for handwashing purposes.⁷



Limited awareness of proper hand hygiene maintenance:

Research suggests that there has been inadequate knowledge of specific handwashing practices in India and related mental models covering germ theory.⁸ A 2022 UNICEF analysis of hand hygiene behaviours in rural India for example found that 15% of household respondents did not know a single step of the correct handwashing process, while 30% knew the correct process.⁹ Even where knowledge exists, it may not always translate into action for maintaining hand hygiene. For instance, as per UNICEF and the WHO, while handwashing with soap

² ADB, Handwashing Benefits are Huge, But It's Tough to Change People's Habits, accessed July 2023

³ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

⁴ National Institute of Urban Affairs (NIUA), e-Gov: Sanitation and Hygiene, 2022

⁵ MoSPI, Multiple Indicator Survey in India, 78th Round, (2020-21), 2023

⁶ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

⁷ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

⁸ WHO International Water Association, Journal of Water & Health, Issue 12, Volume 20, 2022

⁹ UNICEF, Bottleneck analysis of hand hygiene programming, 2022

often increases during epidemics due to health-related fears and increased awareness efforts, these practices tend to wane with time and are usually not sustained, highlighting the knowledge-action gap.¹⁰



Limited monitoring of hand hygiene practices:

There is a need for a regular monitoring mechanism for hand hygiene practices at critical times, such as after defecation, and before eating, in India.¹¹ It recommended that continuous monitoring of the hand hygiene facilities (including access and functionality of facilities), behaviour, and practice of using the facilities at the Gram Panchayat level be undertaken and consolidated by the respective districts, with this information being made available to guide annual planning, budgeting, as required.¹² However, monitoring these behaviours consistently with location-specific granularity has been a challenge.

¹⁰ WHO, UNICEF, State of the World's Hand Hygiene, 2021

¹¹ Centre for Budget and Government Accountability, Commitments towards hand hygiene: Analysis of National, State and District level, 2022

¹² Centre for Budget and Government Accountability, Commitments towards hand hygiene: Analysis of National, State and District level, 2022

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee rural handwashing.



Ministry of Health and Family Welfare¹³

The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare releases guidelines and public health advisories to impart knowledge about the significance of hand hygiene. They train rural social workers such as ASHA and Anganwadi workers (AWWs) to organise educational sessions and teach proper handwashing techniques utilising soap and clean water to rural citizens, including children. Moreover, the ministry actively facilitates the establishment of handwashing stations across rural communities, ensuring accessibility and promoting consistent hand hygiene, especially in schools, health centres, and communal spaces. The ministry also spearheads the National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) which aims to ensure universal access to sanitation and hygiene services.



Ministry of Jal Shakti¹⁴

The Ministry of Jal Shakti houses the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, which is responsible for the Jal Jeevan Mission and the Swachh Bharat Mission. With these missions, the ministry aims to provide safe and adequate drinking water to all households in rural India and ensure universal sanitation coverage, including handwashing with soap. It also conducts surveys such as the National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey and tracks the performance of rural households and schools in promoting handwashing with soap.



Ministry of Education¹⁵

The Department of School Education and Literacy, within the Ministry of Education, oversees the construction of handwashing facilities and ensures the supply of water in rural schools. It issues advisories to states for creating such infrastructure and provides regular training to teachers to impart hygiene education in rural schools.



Ministry of Panchayati Raj

Builds capacity of Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) to deliver WASH services to rural communities, including handwashing with soap.

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to rural handwashing and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.



Swachh Bharat Mission Gramin (SBM-G):

Under Phase II of SBM-G, incentives are provided for constructing latrines, including a water storage facility for handwashing and cleaning to ensure hygiene. The Mission's Information, Education, and Communication component focuses on promoting essential hygienic practices, such as proper drinking water handling and storage, as well as handwashing with soap after use of the toilet, including community or public toilets made available under the Mission, and before eating food.¹⁶

¹³ Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Rural Health Mission, Accessed December 2023

¹⁴ Ministry of Jal Shakti, About Us, Accessed December 2023

¹⁵ Ministry of Education, Centre asks States to create hand washing facilities and train teachers to impart hygiene education to students in all the schools, 2022

¹⁶ Department of Drinking Water & Sanitation, Swachh Bharat Mission - Grameen, accessed July 2023



Kayakalp initiative:

After SBM was launched in October 2014, the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare launched the "Kayakalp" initiative in May 2015 to complement SBM's efforts. The objectives of the "Kayakalp" Scheme are promoting cleanliness, hygiene and infection control in public healthcare facilities, through incentives and recognition to facilities that show good performance in adhering to standard protocols of cleanliness and infection control, enabling a culture of ongoing assessment and review of their hygiene, cleanliness and sanitation performance, and creating and sharing sustainable practices on improved cleanliness in these facilities linked to positive health outcomes. Guidelines include details on hand hygiene practices that should be followed by healthcare workers.¹⁷



Swachh Swasth Sarvatra:

The Swachh Swasth Sarvatra initiative aims to achieve several goals. It enables Gram Panchayats with Kayakalp-awarded Primary Health Centre (PHCs) to become open-defecation-free. It strengthens Community Health Centres (CHCs) in open-defecation-free blocks to achieve a high level of cleanliness. This is done to meet the standards set under Kayakalp standards through funding support. Additionally, it focuses on building the capacity of such CHCs and PHCs. This is accomplished through training in water, sanitation, and hygiene of identified nominees.¹⁸



15th Finance Commission grants to Rural Local Bodies/ Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) for WASH:

The manual on utilisation of the 15th FC grants to rural local bodies and PRI highlights water supply for drinking, handwashing and toilet use to schools, ashram shalas, Anganwadi centres, community centres, health centres, Gram Panchayat buildings, and public places such as weekly bazaar, etc. as an essential indicator.¹⁹



National Rural Health Mission:

The National Rural Health Mission aims for universal access to public services including sanitation and hygiene to ensure the effective integration of health concerns in rural areas of the country.²⁰



Jal Jeevan Mission:

The Jal Jeevan Mission aims to supply regular, adequate potable water to every rural household in the country. This can enable enhanced hand hygiene at household levels.²¹



Private sector partnerships:

Several private sector initiatives aim to promote personal hygiene and public health behaviour and practices. Some prominent examples are Unilever's 'Swachh Aadat, Swachh Bharat' campaign and NDTV and Dettol's 'Banega Swachh India' campaigns on public health and hygiene.²²



Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya:

This national campaign aims to develop and support appropriate health and hygiene behaviours among students by ensuring every school in India has a set of functioning and well-maintained water, sanitation, and hygiene facilities.²³

¹⁷ Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Guidelines for the implementation of the Kayakalp initiative, accessed August 2023

¹⁸ Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Ministry of Jal Shakti, Operational Guidelines for Swachh Swasth Sarvatra, 2018

¹⁹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Manual for the utilization of 15 Finance Commission tied grants to Rural Local Bodies/ PRIs for water & sanitation (2021-22 to 2025-26), 2021

²⁰ Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Health Mission, accessed July 2023

²¹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Jal Jeevan Mission, accessed July 2023

²² HUL, Suvidha – bringing hygiene and sanitation to urban communities, 2021; NDTV-Dettol, Banega Swachh India, accessed July 2023

²³ Ministry of Education, Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya, accessed July 2023

Way forward

Handwashing with soap is a critical public health intervention that can provide significant benefits with very low marginal costs. Though progress has been made in India with the provision of handwashing stations and a significant focus on behaviour change, more is needed to ensure universal adoption of this behaviour.

Some ideas that can drive progress are:

 Enhancing monitoring of handwashing behaviour	Greater investments are necessary to increase the monitoring of handwashing behaviours at a granular level and plan both infrastructural and behavioural interventions based on such data and observations. Innovative methods to enable data can be enabled such as the use of mobile phones for reporting the status of handwashing stations, as well as Internet-of-Things and SMS-based data capturing systems that have previously been used in Indian cities to monitor water supply.
 Adopting a scientific behavioural lens	Historically, handwashing has been approached as a communication problem and IEC materials and even some gamified practices have been deployed at scale. However, there might be merit in exploring a wider range of behavioural levers – such as choice architecture or even the physical design and placement of handwashing stations. Additionally, incorporating adjustments for height and other biases can enhance the usability of handwashing stations.
 Ensuring adequate water and soap supply	Schools and communities should always have access to soap and running water at handwashing facilities. Government agencies can explore collaborations with CSR, domestic philanthropies, and other development partners to ensure this.

Recommended readings

CBGA India. (2022). *Commitments towards hand hygiene: Analysis of National, State and District level programmes, finances, and capacities*

<https://www.cbgaindia.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/09/commitments-towards-hand-hygiene-analysis-of-national-state-and-district-level-programmes-finances-and-capacities.pdf>

UNICEF and IRC. (2022). *Measuring Hand Hygiene for all: A framework for monitoring and reporting hand hygiene in India.*

https://www.ircwash.org/sites/default/files/hand_hygiene_-_monitoring_and_reporting_framework_22_july.pdf

WHO and UNICEF. (2021) *State of the World's Hand Hygiene: A global call to action to make hand hygiene a priority in policy and practice.*

<https://www.unicef.org/media/108356/file/State%20of%20the%20World%E2%80%99s%20Hand%20Hygiene.pdf>



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